

Question ID: e38b3e4f

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

The radiation that _____ during the decay of radioactive atomic nuclei is known as gamma radiation.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. occurs
- B. have occurred
- C. occur
- D. are occurring

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "occurs" agrees in number with the singular subject "radiation."

Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have occurred" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "radiation." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "occur" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "radiation." Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb "are occurring" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "radiation."

Question ID: 37e5c794

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Despite being cheap, versatile, and easy to produce, _____ they are made from nonrenewable petroleum, and most do not biodegrade in landfills.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. there are two problems associated with commercial plastics:
- B. two problems are associated with commercial plastics:
- C. commercial plastics’ two associated problems are that
- D. commercial plastics have two associated problems:

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice ensures that the modifying phrase “despite being cheap, versatile, and easy to produce” appears immediately before the noun it modifies, “commercial plastics,” clearly establishing that the commercial plastics—and not another noun in the sentence—are being described as cheap, versatile, and easy to produce.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the function word “there” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically and confusingly suggests that “there” is cheap, versatile, and easy to produce. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun “two problems” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “problems” are cheap, versatile, and easy to produce. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “commercial plastics’ two associated problems” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “problems” are cheap, versatile, and easy to produce.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

On April 5, 1977, Kitty Cone and 150 other disability rights activists entered a San Francisco federal building. After pleading for years—to no effect—for the passage of key antidiscrimination legislation, _____ until their demands were addressed. Finally, on April 28, the legislation was signed.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. pressure on lawmakers increased when the activists staged a sit-in protest
- B. a sit-in protest staged by the activists increased pressure on lawmakers
- C. lawmakers came under increased pressure when the activists staged a sit-in protest
- D. the activists increased pressure on lawmakers by staging a sit-in protest

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase “the activists” the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase “after...legislation.” In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the activists—and not another noun in the sentence—were pleading for the passage of antidiscrimination legislation.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “pressure on lawmakers” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “pressure” was pleading for the passage of antidiscrimination legislation. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “a sit-in protest” immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the “protest” was pleading for the passage of antidiscrimination legislation. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase “lawmakers” immediately after the modifying phrase suggests that “lawmakers” were pleading for the passage of antidiscrimination legislation. While it’s possible for lawmakers to plead for the passage of legislation, the context strongly suggests that it’s the activists who pleaded for years for the passage of antidiscrimination legislation.

Question ID: 3a1239d2

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

If an animal can recognize itself in a reflective surface (“the mirror test”), it is considered to have self-awareness. In a recent study, scientists _____ for evidence of self-awareness in snakes, species that rely primarily on olfactory rather than visual processing, adapted the test to foreground smell, modifying the scent trails of North American eastern garter snakes and African ball pythons.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. searched
- B. searching
- C. were searching
- D. have searched

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. The nonfinite present participle “searching” is correctly used to form a supplementary element that modifies the subject “scientists,” indicating that the scientists who adapted the test were looking for evidence of self-awareness in snakes.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite past tense verb “searched” can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element that indicates what evidence the scientists who adapted the test were looking for. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite past progressive verb “were searching” can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element that indicates what evidence the scientists who adapted the test were looking for. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present perfect verb “have searched” can’t be used in this way to form a supplementary element that indicates what evidence the scientists who adapted the test were looking for.

Question ID: 3580533b

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In recent years, economists around the world have created new tools that quantify the overall well-being of a country’s citizens. Economists in India, for example, use an Ease of Living Index. This tool _____ economic potential, sustainability, and citizens’ quality of life.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. measures
- B. had measured
- C. would have measured
- D. will have been measuring

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The previous sentence tells us how economists in India "use" a certain tool, while this sentence describes general facts about that tool. To express general facts (and also to match the simple present tense of "use"), we should use the simple present tense form "measures."

Choice B is incorrect. This choice uses the past perfect tense, but the previous sentence tells us that the tool is currently used to measure things, so the past tense doesn't make sense for this verb. Choice C is incorrect. This choice uses the future perfect conditional tense, but the previous sentence tells us that the tool is currently used to measure things, so the future tense doesn't make sense for this verb. Choice D is incorrect. This choice uses the future perfect continuous tense, but the previous sentence tells us that the tool is currently used to measure things, so the future tense doesn't make sense for this verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

French philosopher René Descartes doubted whether he could prove his own existence. Eventually, he found proof in his famous phrase “I think, therefore I am.” The _____ complexity: only those who exist would be able to ponder their existence.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. phrases’ simplicity masks its
- B. phrases simplicity masks their
- C. phrase’s simplicity masks their
- D. phrase’s simplicity masks its

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The conventions being tested are the use of possessive nouns and the use of possessive determiners. The singular possessive noun "phrase's" correctly indicates that there is only one simple phrase. The singular possessive determiner "its" agrees in number with the singular possessive noun "phrase's," reinforcing the idea that there is only one simple yet complex phrase.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "phrase's," not the plural possessive noun "phrases'." Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "phrase's" and the corresponding singular possessive determiner "its," not the plural noun "phrases" and the corresponding plural possessive determiner "their." Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive determiner "its," not the plural possessive determiner "their."

Question ID: e62241b7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

What is the correct pronunciation of Kiribati? In the Gilbertese language spoken by residents of the island nation, the letter combination -ti makes the -s sound; as a result, the country’s name _____ pronounced “Kiribas.”

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. are
- B. have been
- C. are being
- D. is

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "is" agrees in number with the singular subject "the country’s name."

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "are" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "the country’s name." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have been" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "the country’s name." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "are being" doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject "the country’s name."

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

American abstract artist Richard _____ his installations to make passersby keenly aware of how one’s movements are affected by the physical features of one’s environment, assembles large-scale steel plates into sculptures that dominate the outdoor spaces they occupy.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Serra is intending
- B. Serra, intends
- C. Serra, intending
- D. Serra intends

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. This choice pairs the comma after "Serra" with the comma after "environment" and uses the nonfinite present participle "intending" to correctly form a supplementary phrase describing the reaction Serra intends his sculptures to provoke. This supplementary phrase appears between the noun phrase that it modifies ("American abstract artist Richard Serra") and the finite present tense verb ("assembles"), which functions as the sentence’s main verb and describes what Serra does.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present continuous tense verb "is intending" can’t be used in this way in conjunction with the finite present tense verb "assembles," which already functions as the main verb in the sentence. Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present tense verb "intends" can’t be used in this way to supplement the noun phrase "American abstract artist Richard Serra." Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The finite present tense verb "intends" can’t be used in this way in conjunction with the finite present tense verb "assembles," which already functions as the main verb in the sentence.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Mathematician and meteorologist Edward Lorenz used the metaphor of the “butterfly effect” to explain how seemingly minor events can have major impacts on future weather. According to Lorenz’s metaphor, the wind from a butterfly flapping _____ in Brazil might eventually grow into a storm elsewhere across the globe.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. its wings
- B. its wings’
- C. it’s wing’s
- D. it’s wings’

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The conventions being tested are the use of possessive determiners and plural nouns. The singular possessive determiner "its" and the plural noun "wings" correctly indicate that the butterfly has multiple wings.

Choice B is incorrect because the context requires the plural noun "wings," not the plural possessive noun "wings’." Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive determiner "its" and the plural noun "wings," not the contraction "it’s" and the singular possessive noun "wing’s." Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive determiner "its" and the plural noun "wings," not the contraction "it’s" and the plural possessive noun "wings’."

Question ID: 908a76b8

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

When a given industry—water and electricity are two well-known examples—carries high infrastructural start-up costs and other barriers that discourage competition, _____ of just one or two suppliers per municipality. Such industries are known as natural monopolies.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. these often consist
- B. they often consist
- C. it often consists
- D. this often consists

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is pronoun-antecedent agreement. The singular pronoun "it" agrees in number with the singular antecedent "industry" and clearly indicates that the industry consists of just one or two suppliers per municipality.

Choice A is incorrect. The plural pronoun "these" neither agrees in number with the singular antecedent "industry" nor clearly indicates that the industry—not another plural noun in the sentence, such as "start-up costs" or "barriers"—consists of just one or two suppliers per municipality. Choice B is incorrect because the plural pronoun "they" doesn't agree in number with the singular antecedent "industry." Choice D is incorrect because the singular pronoun "this" is ambiguous in this context; the resulting sentence leaves unclear what consists of just one or two suppliers per municipality.

Question ID: 1ee7b429

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Bonnie Buratti of NASA’s Jet Propulsion Laboratory _____ data about Saturn’s rings collected by the *Cassini* spacecraft when she made an interesting discovery: the tiny moons embedded between and within Saturn’s rings are shaped by the buildup of ring material on the moons’ surfaces.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. studies
- B. has been studying
- C. will study
- D. was studying

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense in a sentence. In this choice, the past progressive tense verb “was studying” is consistent with the other past tense verbs (e.g., “made” and “collected”) used to describe Buratti’s discovery. Further, the past progressive tense correctly indicates that an ongoing action in the past was occurring (she was studying) at the same time that another event occurred in the past (she made an interesting discovery).

Choice A is incorrect because the present tense verb “studies” isn’t consistent with the past tense verbs used to describe Buratti’s discovery. Choice B is incorrect because the present perfect progressive tense verb “has been studying” isn’t consistent with the past tense verbs used to describe Buratti’s discovery. Choice C is incorrect because the future tense verb “will study” isn’t consistent with the past tense verbs used to describe Buratti’s discovery.

Question ID: 4c335aea

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In a recent analysis of lyrical trends in 350,000 songs, researchers cite increases in certain measures, such as the ratio of choruses to verses, as evidence music lyrics are becoming more repetitive. For instance, from 1970 to 2020, _____ chorus-to-verse ratios trended similarly, with each genre’s data indicating that relative to the number of unique verses, the number of repeated choruses in songs increased.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. rocks and raps
- B. rock’s and rap’s
- C. rocks and rap’s
- D. rock and rap’s

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of possessive nouns. The singular possessive nouns "rock’s" and "rap’s" correctly indicate that the chorus-to-verse ratios belong to the genres of rock and rap.

Choice A is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive nouns "rock’s" and "rap’s," not the plural nouns "rocks" and "raps."

Choice C is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "rock’s," not the plural noun "rocks." Choice D is incorrect because the context requires the singular possessive noun "rock’s," not the singular noun "rock." This choice incorrectly suggests that there was a single chorus-to-verse ratio for rock and rap together, whereas the ratio was calculated for each genre individually.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Supported by biochemical analyses of over 2,000 skeletons from the Middle Ages, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. vegetables and grains were, a 2022 study found, the primary components of early medieval rulers’ diets.
- B. early medieval rulers’ diets were found, in a 2022 study, to have primarily consisted of vegetables and grains.
- C. the primary components of early medieval rulers’ diets were vegetables and grains, according to a 2022 study.
- D. findings from a 2022 study suggested that vegetables and grains were the primary components of early medieval rulers’ diets.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "findings from a 2022 study" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "supported...Ages." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the findings—and not another noun in the sentence—are supported by the biochemical analyses.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "vegetables and grains" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that vegetables and grains are supported by biochemical analyses. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "early medieval rulers’ diets" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the rulers’ diets are supported by biochemical analyses. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "the primary components" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the primary components are supported by biochemical analyses.

Question ID: 9127635a

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Star actress Kiki Omeili, who has appeared in 47 Nollywood films, is one of numerous luminaries to be pictured in Nigerian portraitist Iké Udé’s exhibition *Nollywood Portraits*. _____ referred to Nollywood—Nigeria’s \$3 billion film industry—as “Africa’s vivid mirror par excellence,” honors its legacy with his vivid classical portraits of Omeili and her peers.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. Udé, has
- B. Udé has
- C. Udé
- D. Udé, having

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms and punctuation within a sentence. The sentence’s subject is “Udé,” and its finite main verb is “honors.” This choice correctly uses the nonfinite participle “having referred” to form a supplementary element (“having...excellence”) describing Udé. The comma after “Udé” appropriately marks the boundary before that supplementary element.

Choice A is incorrect because using the finite verb “has referred” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “honors,” so “has referred” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions. Moreover, no punctuation is needed when a subject (“Udé”) is immediately followed by a finite verb (“has referred”). Choice B is incorrect because using the finite verb “has referred” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “honors,” so “has referred” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions. Choice C is incorrect because using the finite verb “referred” creates an ungrammatical sentence. The sentence already has the finite main verb “honors,” so “referred” can’t also function as a second main verb here without additional punctuation or conjunctions.

Question ID: 36e89f74

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

An imposing spire of igneous rock rising high above the Belle Fourche River in eastern Wyoming, Devils Tower (also known as Bear Lodge) is one of the most prominent examples of columnar jointing, a pattern of fracturing in rocks that _____ in parallel arrays of long polygonal prisms.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. resulting
- B. were resulting
- C. results
- D. to result

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. Relative clauses, such as the one beginning with “that,” require a finite (tensed) verb, a verb that can function as the main verb of a clause. This choice correctly supplies the clause with the finite present tense verb “results.” Furthermore, the simple present tense verb “results” correctly indicates that the formation of parallel arrays of long polygonal prisms is an enduring property of this fracturing pattern.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle “resulting” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb. Choice B is incorrect because the past progressive tense verb “were resulting” doesn’t indicate that the formation of parallel arrays of long polygonal prisms is an enduring property of this fracturing pattern. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive “to result” doesn’t supply the clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

The rough frog is a species of amphibian native to Australia. Currently, the frog’s range _____ parts of northern New South Wales and southeastern Queensland.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. includes
- B. included
- C. will have included
- D. had included

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense in a sentence. In this choice, the present tense verb “includes,” used in conjunction with the word “currently,” correctly indicates that the frog’s current range includes parts of northern New South Wales and southeastern Queensland.

Choice B is incorrect because the past tense verb “included” doesn’t indicate that the frog’s range currently includes parts of northern New South Wales and southeastern Queensland. Choice C is incorrect because the future perfect tense “will have included” doesn’t indicate that the frog’s range currently includes parts of northern New South Wales and southeastern Queensland. Choice D is incorrect because the past perfect tense “had included” doesn’t indicate that the frog’s range currently includes parts of northern New South Wales and southeastern Queensland.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Entomologists Yash Sondhi and Samuel Fabian have tried to explain why moths fly erratically around light sources at night. Knowing that flying insects keep their backs pointed toward sunlight during the day, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. the researchers theorize that moths, mistaking nighttime lights for the Sun, continually try to reorient their bodies while flying near such lights.
- B. the researchers’ theory is that moths mistake nighttime lights for the Sun, continually trying to reorient their bodies while flying near such lights.
- C. moths mistake nighttime lights for the Sun and continually try to reorient their bodies while flying near such lights, the researchers theorize.
- D. moths continually try to reorient their bodies while flying near nighttime lights, the researchers theorize, mistaking such lights for the Sun.

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "the researchers" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "knowing...day." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the researchers—and not another noun in the sentence—know that flying insects keep their backs pointed toward sunlight during the day.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun phrase "the researchers’ theory" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that the researchers’ theory knows that flying insects keep their backs pointed toward sunlight during the day. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun "moths" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that moths know that flying insects keep their backs pointed toward sunlight during the day. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of the noun "moths" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that moths know that flying insects keep their backs pointed toward sunlight during the day.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

In her 1983 book *The Managed Heart: Commercialization of Human Feeling*, sociologist Arlie Russell Hochschild first explored at length her conception of a “sociology of emotions”—the idea that the various cultural and ideological frameworks a person has internalized (class, gender, political affiliation, etc.) _____ each emotional reaction that person has within a situation.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. underlies
- B. is underlying
- C. underlie
- D. has been underlying

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The plural verb "underlie" agrees in number with the plural subject "frameworks."

Choice A is incorrect because the singular verb "underlies" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "frameworks." Choice B is incorrect because the singular verb "is underlying" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "frameworks." Choice D is incorrect because the singular verb "has been underlying" doesn't agree in number with the plural subject "frameworks."

Question ID: 83617355

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Each night in Gijón, Spain, a section of the city’s marina is bathed in a soft green glow. The source of the glow is the Árbol de la Sidra, a large sculpture made up of 3,200 recycled glass bottles. A lamp inside the tree-shaped structure _____ the green glass.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. will be illuminating
- B. illuminates
- C. would illuminate
- D. illuminated

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense. In this choice, the present tense verb "illuminates" is consistent with the other present tense verb ("is") used to describe the sculpture, correctly indicating that the sculpture habitually glows ("each night") and that the lamp inside is the source of its illumination.

Choice A is incorrect because the future progressive tense verb "will be illuminating" isn't consistent with the other present tense verb used to describe the sculpture and the source of its glow. Choice C is incorrect because the modal "would," which is used to indicate a typical behavior in the past, isn't consistent with the other present tense verb used to describe the sculpture and the source of its glow. Choice D is incorrect because the past tense verb "illuminated" isn't consistent with the other present tense verb used to describe the sculpture and the source of its glow.

Question ID: 16740ab4

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

At the Chicxulub asteroid impact crater in Mexico, the presence of many fossilized microbacteria, which seem to have thrived there despite the extreme heat that persisted after the Chicxulub impact, _____ claims that bacteria are among the planet’s most resilient organisms.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. have reinforced
- B. reinforces
- C. are reinforcing
- D. reinforce

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb “reinforces” agrees in number with the singular subject “the presence.”

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb “have reinforced” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the presence.” Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “are reinforcing” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the presence.” Choice D is incorrect because the plural verb “reinforce” doesn’t agree in number with the singular subject “the presence.”

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

Rabinal Achí is a precolonial Maya dance drama performed annually in Rabinal, a town in the Guatemalan highlands. Based on events that occurred when Rabinal was a city-state ruled by a king, _____ had once been an ally of the king but was later captured while leading an invading force against him.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. *Rabinal Achí* tells the story of K'iche' Achí, a military leader who
- B. K'iche' Achí, the military leader in the story of *Rabinal Achí*,
- C. the military leader whose story is told in *Rabinal Achí*, K'iche' Achí,
- D. there was a military leader, K'iche' Achí, who in *Rabinal Achí*

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma.

Choice B is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma. Choice C is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma. Choice D is incorrect. This doesn’t complete the text in a way that conforms to the conventions of Standard English. The modifier “Based on events...by a king,” is describing the drama “Rabinal Achí.” Modifiers need to be next to the subjects they describe, so “Rabinal Achí” needs to be the first word after the comma.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

During the American Civil War, Thomas Morris Chester braved the front lines as a war correspondent for the *Philadelphia Press*. Amplifying the voices and experiences of Black soldiers _____ of particular importance to Chester, who later became an activist and lawyer during the postwar Reconstruction period.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. were
- B. have been
- C. are
- D. was

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement. The singular verb "was" agrees in number with the singular subject "amplifying." Gerunds such as "amplifying" are always singular.

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb "were" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "amplifying." Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb "have been" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "amplifying." Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb "are" doesn't agree in number with the singular subject "amplifying."

Question ID: 7b419faf

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In 1903, environmentalist John Muir guided President Theodore Roosevelt on a scenic, sprawling trip through California’s Yosemite Valley. Upon returning from the three-day excursion, Roosevelt _____ to conserve the nation’s wilderness areas, a vow he upheld for his remaining six years in office.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. is vowing
- B. vowed
- C. will vow
- D. vows

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense in a sentence. In this choice, the past tense verb “vowed” is consistent with the other past tense verbs (“guided” and “upheld”) used to narrate the events surrounding President Roosevelt’s decision to conserve the nation’s wilderness areas.

Choice A is incorrect because the present progressive tense verb “is vowing” isn’t consistent with the past tense verbs used to narrate the events surrounding President Roosevelt’s decision to conserve the nation’s wilderness areas. Choice C is incorrect because the future tense verb “will vow” isn’t consistent with the past tense verbs used to narrate the events surrounding President Roosevelt’s decision to conserve the nation’s wilderness areas. Choice D is incorrect because the simple present tense verb “vows” isn’t consistent with the past tense verbs used to narrate the events surrounding President Roosevelt’s decision to conserve the nation’s wilderness areas.

Question ID: 29c9be28

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

To survive when water is scarce, embryos inside African turquoise killifish eggs _____ a dormant state known as diapause. In this state, embryonic development is paused for as long as two years—longer than the life span of an adult killifish.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. enter
- B. to enter
- C. having entered
- D. entering

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is finite and nonfinite verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, “embryos”), and this choice supplies the clause with the finite present tense verb “enter” to indicate how the embryos achieve diapause.

Choice B is incorrect because the nonfinite to-infinitive “to enter” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “having entered” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “entering” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Question ID: 983d33fa

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

In 1637, the price of tulips skyrocketed in Amsterdam, with single bulbs of rare varieties selling for up to the equivalent of \$200,000 in today’s US dollars. Some historians _____ that this “tulip mania” was the first historical instance of an asset bubble, which occurs when investors drive prices to highs not supported by actual demand.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. claiming
- B. claim
- C. having claimed
- D. to claim

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of finite and nonfinite verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, “some historians”), and this choice supplies the finite present tense verb “claim” to indicate what some historians do.

Choice A is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “claiming” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because the nonfinite participle “having claimed” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because the nonfinite to-infinitive “to claim” doesn’t supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Question ID: 6e193b19

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Medium

Question

Professional American football player Fred Cox invented one of the world’s most popular toys. In the 1970s, he came up with the idea for the Nerf football, which _____ of the harder and heavier regulation football.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. were a smaller, foam version
- B. are smaller, foam versions
- C. were smaller, foam versions
- D. is a smaller, foam version

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-verb agreement and agreement between nouns. The singular verb “is” and the singular noun “version” both agree in number with the relative pronoun “which.” In this context, “which” functions as a singular subject because it refers to the singular noun “the Nerf football.”

Choice A is incorrect because the plural verb “were” doesn’t agree in number with the singular noun phrase “the Nerf football” that it’s modifying. Choice B is incorrect because the plural verb “are” and the plural noun “versions” don’t agree in number with the singular noun phrase “the Nerf football” that they’re modifying. Choice C is incorrect because the plural verb “were” and the plural noun “versions” don’t agree in number with the singular noun phrase “the Nerf football” that they’re modifying.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Hard

Question

The Herfindahl-Hirschman Index (HHI), a commonly used measure of competition between companies in a particular market, ranges from a score of zero to 10,000 points. Compared with that of a highly concentrated market—that is, a market controlled by very few companies—_____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. a market that is less concentrated will have a much lower HHI score.
- B. the HHI score of a less concentrated market will be much lower.
- C. when a market is less concentrated, its HHI score will be much lower.
- D. a less concentrated market will have an HHI score that is much lower.

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is subject-modifier placement. This choice makes the noun phrase "the HHI...market" the subject of the sentence and places it immediately after the modifying phrase "compared...market." In doing so, this choice clearly establishes that the HHI score of a less concentrated market—and not another noun in the sentence—is being compared with the HHI score of a highly concentrated market.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "a market that is less concentrated" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that a market is being compared with an HHI score. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a confusing, illogical sentence. The placement of the modifier "when a market is less concentrated" after "a highly concentrated market" is contradictory. Furthermore, it's ambiguous what "its" is referring to in "its HHI score," resulting in an illogical comparison. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a dangling modifier. The placement of "a less concentrated market" immediately after the modifying phrase illogically suggests that a market is being compared with an HHI score.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

According to the traditional RYB (red-yellow-blue) color model, yellow is a complementary color to purple. However, yellow _____ considered complementary to blue in modern color theory.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. is
- B. having been
- C. to be
- D. being

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verb forms within a sentence. A main clause requires a finite (tensed) verb to perform the action of the subject (in this case, "yellow"), and this choice supplies the present tense verb "is considered" to indicate that yellow is considered a complementary color to blue in modern color theory.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "having been considered" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice C is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite to-infinitive "to be considered" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb. Choice D is incorrect because it results in an ungrammatical sentence. The nonfinite participle "being considered" doesn't supply the main clause with a finite verb.

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Formed in 1967 to foster political and economic stability within the Asia-Pacific region, the Association of Southeast Asian Nations was originally made up of five members: Thailand, the Philippines, Singapore, Malaysia, and Indonesia. By the end of the 1990s, the organization _____ its initial membership.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. has doubled
- B. had doubled
- C. doubles
- D. will double

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense. In this choice, the past perfect verb “had doubled” properly indicates that the doubling of the organization’s initial membership occurred during a specific period before the present (between the organization’s founding in 1967 and the end of the 1990s).

Choice A is incorrect because the present perfect verb “has doubled” doesn’t indicate that the organization’s doubling of its initial membership occurred during a specific period in the past. Choice C is incorrect because the present tense verb “doubles” doesn’t indicate that the organization’s doubling of its initial membership occurred during a specific period in the past. Choice D is incorrect because the future tense verb “will double” doesn’t indicate that the organization’s doubling of its initial membership occurred during a specific period in the past.

Question ID: 96c720af

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Form, Structure, and Sense	Easy

Question

Atoms in a synchrotron, a type of circular particle accelerator, travel faster and faster until they _____ a desired energy level, at which point they are diverted to collide with a target, smashing the atoms.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. will reach
- B. reach
- C. had reached
- D. are reaching

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of verbs to express tense in a sentence. In this choice, the present tense verb “reach” is consistent with the present tense verbs “travel” and “are diverted” used to describe how atoms move through the synchrotron.

Choice A is incorrect because the future tense verb “will reach” is inconsistent with the present tense verbs used to describe how atoms move through the synchrotron. Though the atoms’ movement is a recurring action and “will reach” can also be used to indicate a habitual or recurring action, it creates a logical inconsistency in this sentence when paired with the present tense verbs “travel” and “are diverted.” Choice C is incorrect because the past perfect tense verb “had reached” is inconsistent with the present tense verbs used to describe how atoms move through the synchrotron. Choice D is incorrect because the present progressive tense verb “are reaching” is inconsistent with the present tense verbs used to describe how atoms move through the synchrotron. While both verbs occur in the present, the present progressive tense suggests that the action is currently in progress. This creates a logical inconsistency when paired with the present tense verbs “travel” and “are diverted,” which offer a general description of the tendencies of the atoms’ movement, rather than a description of an action that is currently in progress.